knocked two systems together head to head," he continued, claiming that his gamble had paid off. He then explained the deal that he was going to offer the Americans: "Kennedy says to us: take your missiles out of Cuba. We answer: give firm guarantees and promises that the Americans will not attack Cuba. That's not bad. We could take out our R-12s and leave other missiles there." By "other missiles" he probably meant tactical nuclear weapons.

"This is not cowardice," said Khrushchev, returning to the subject of capitulation, "it's a reserve position." If so, then it was the first that Khrushchev's colleagues had heard of it. He reassured them that the removal of the missiles would not hurt Soviet prospects of staying on par with the United States. "Besides, there's no need to bring the situation to a boiling point; we can destroy the USA from the territory of the USSR just as well," he argued. "We should play our part, but without trying to wiggle out, without losing our heads. The initiative is in our hands; there is nothing to fear." He then turned the whole issue of fear inside out. "Began and chickened out," Khrushchev told his aides: the note in the protocol is too laconic to make it clear whether he meant the Americans or himself. He then continued. "Fighting is not to our advantage: the future does not depend on Cuba but on our country—that's for sure."

The members of the Presidium, some of whom, like Mikoyan, were clearly relieved, supported their boss. "A correct and reasonable tactic," wrote the notetaker, summarizing their views. "Now Cuba is not the same as it was before the events. Do not aggravate the situation. In this manner we will strengthen Cuba." This resonated with Khrushchev's own argument. He said to the gathering: "Cuba will be different from what it was earlier. They [the Americans] are threatening an economic blockade, but the USA will not attack Cuba. We should not aggravate the situation but conduct a rational policy. That way we will strengthen Cuba and save it for two-three years, and in a few years it will be even harder to get the better of it."

With the decision reached and consensus attained, the meeting moved on to discuss how to break the news of the Soviet withdrawal of nuclear weapons to Castro. "Some things worked out well, others did not," said Khrushchev, trying to strike a philosophical tone. "What we have right now is a positive moment. What is the positive side of this? The fact that the